

FLORA WELLNESS

Complete Guide Series | Volume 02

The Hormone Meal Bible

200+ Hormone-Balancing Recipes & Complete
Nutrition System for Women

Eat your way to balanced hormones — every meal, every phase

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SECTION 1: NUTRITION FUNDAMENTALS FOR HORMONE HEALTH

How Food Directly Controls Hormone Production

Every hormone in your body is built from the raw materials you eat. Steroid hormones (estrogen, progesterone, testosterone, cortisol, DHEA) are all synthesized from cholesterol — meaning adequate dietary fat is essential for hormone production. Peptide hormones (insulin, growth hormone, thyroid hormones) are built from amino acids, meaning adequate protein intake is critical. Neurotransmitters that modulate hormonal signalling are synthesized from amino acids, vitamins, and minerals.

When you under-eat, restrict fat, or avoid animal protein, you are literally starving your hormone-producing machinery of its raw materials. This is why low-fat, low-calorie diets reliably worsen hormonal symptoms in women. The Hormone Meal Bible takes the opposite approach: strategic nutritional abundance with targeted foods that provide exactly what your endocrine system needs.

Macronutrients and Hormones

Macronutrient	Hormone Role	Best Sources	Common Mistakes	Daily Target
Protein	Precursor to peptide hormones, neurotransmitters, enzymes; stabilizes blood sugar	Wild fish, organic eggs, grass-fed meat, legumes, organic tempeh	Too little (under 80g/day) — crashes blood sugar, depletes neurotransmitters	0.7-1g per lb body weight
Healthy Fat	Cholesterol = steroid hormone backbone; fat-soluble vitamins D, A, K, E	Avocado, olive oil, coconut oil, oily fish, grass-fed butter, egg yolks	Fat phobia from 1990s diet culture — still persists and wrecks hormones	30-40% of calories

Macronutrient	Hormone Role	Best Sources	Common Mistakes	Daily Target
Complex Carbs	Blood sugar stability, gut microbiome fuel, serotonin production, thyroid	Root vegetables, legumes, whole grains, fruit, squash	Ultra-refined carbs — spike insulin, crash energy, drive inflammation	30-40% of calories; time to meals/phases
Fiber	Estrogen clearance via gut, bile support, microbiome diversity	Vegetables, legumes, seeds, berries, whole grains	Under 20g/day — estrogen recirculates; constipation is hormone disaster	30-35g daily minimum

Critical Micronutrients for Hormone Synthesis

Nutrient	Hormones Supported	Deficiency Signs	Best Food Sources	Daily Target
Magnesium	Progesterone, cortisol, insulin, thyroid	PMS, insomnia, anxiety, constipation, muscle cramps	Dark leafy greens, pumpkin seeds, dark chocolate, almonds, avocado	400-500mg
Zinc	Progesterone, testosterone, thyroid, insulin	Low libido, poor immunity, hair loss, delayed wound healing	Oysters, pumpkin seeds, beef, chickpeas, cashews	15-30mg
Vitamin B6	Progesterone synthesis, estrogen metabolism, serotonin	PMS mood changes, anxiety, water retention before period	Chicken, tuna, salmon, bananas, sunflower seeds	50-100mg (as P5P)

Nutrient	Hormones Supported	Deficiency Signs	Best Food Sources	Daily Target
Selenium	Thyroid T4→T3 conversion, anti-Hashimoto's	Fatigue, hair loss, immune issues, thyroid symptoms	Brazil nuts (2/day), sardines, tuna, eggs	200mcg
Iodine	Thyroid hormone production (T3 and T4)	Fatigue, weight gain, brain fog, fibrocystic breasts	Seaweed (nori, kelp), seafood, eggs, iodized salt	150-300mcg
Vitamin D3	Hormone synthesis, insulin, immunity, anti-inflammatory	Low mood, poor immunity, bone loss, cycle irregularity	Fatty fish, egg yolks, UV-exposed mushrooms + sunlight	2000-5000 IU
Iron (Ferritin)	Energy, thyroid, dopamine, mitochondrial function	Fatigue, brain fog, hair loss, heavy periods made worse	Grass-fed beef, oysters, liver, lentils, pumpkin seeds, spinach	Target ferritin >70
Omega-3 EPA/DHA	Prostaglandins, inflammation, cell membranes, brain	PMS pain, dry skin, depression, poor focus, inflammation	Wild salmon, sardines, mackerel, anchovies, herring, flaxseed	2-3g combined EPA+DHA
Choline	Estrogen metabolism, liver detox, cell membranes	Fatty liver, poor estrogen clearance, brain fog	Eggs (especially yolks), liver, salmon, shrimp, broccoli	450-550mg

SECTION 2: THE HORMONE FOOD PYRAMID

Eat This Every Day: Foundation Foods

Protein at Every Meal

Wild-caught fish (salmon, sardines, mackerel, anchovies), organic eggs (whole, with yolk), organic poultry, grass-fed beef/lamb, legumes and lentils, organic tempeh and edamame

Vegetables — Fill Half Your Plate

At least 1-2 cups cruciferous vegetables daily (broccoli, kale, Brussels sprouts, cauliflower, arugula), plus abundant leafy greens, root vegetables, alliums (garlic, onions, leeks)

Healthy Fats — Every Meal

Avocado ($\frac{1}{2}$ daily), extra virgin olive oil (2-3 tbsp daily), nuts and seeds (1 oz daily), grass-fed butter or ghee, coconut oil for cooking

Fiber-Rich Complex Carbs

Sweet potato, squash, root vegetables, legumes, quinoa, whole oats, berries, apples — adjust amounts to your phase and insulin sensitivity

Hormone-Protective Herbs & Spices

Turmeric + black pepper daily, rosemary, fresh ginger, cinnamon (blood sugar), maca, adaptogenic herbs

Foods That Disrupt Hormones — The Avoidance List

Food/Drink	How It Disrupts Hormones	How Often	Alternative
Refined sugar	Spikes insulin, raises cortisol, drives inflammation, depletes B vitamins and zinc	Eliminate (or very rarely)	Medjool dates, raw honey, maple syrup in small amounts
Alcohol	Blocks estrogen clearance in liver, depletes zinc and B vitamins, disrupts sleep	Eliminate during reset; ≤1x/week maintenance	Kombucha, sparkling water, mocktails
Conventional dairy	Synthetic hormones in milk, inflammatory A1 casein, acne-driving IGF-1	Eliminate trial 30 days	Organic sheep/goat dairy, coconut yogurt, nut milks
Non-organic soy (excess)	Phytoestrogens in excess can block receptor sites; GMO soy disrupts thyroid	Avoid processed soy; organic edamame/tempeh fine in moderation	Organic edamame, organic tempeh, organic miso
Gluten (if Hashimoto's)	Molecular mimicry triggers thyroid autoantibodies in susceptible women	Strict elimination if Hashimoto's confirmed	Rice, quinoa, oats (certified GF), root vegetables
Caffeine (excess)	Raises cortisol, depletes magnesium and B vitamins, disrupts sleep, worsens PMS	Max 1 cup before noon; eliminate during reset	Green tea (less cortisol impact), matcha, herbal tea
Refined vegetable oils	Pro-inflammatory omega-6 excess disrupts prostaglandin balance, damages cell membranes	Avoid entirely	EVOO, avocado oil, coconut oil, grass-fed butter

SECTION 3: ESTROGEN-BALANCING NUTRITION

The Cruciferous Protocol

No other food category has more evidence for supporting healthy estrogen metabolism than cruciferous vegetables. The glucosinolates in cruciferous vegetables — particularly broccoli, Brussels sprouts, and kale — convert to indole-3-carbinol (I3C) during digestion. I3C then converts to DIM (diindylmethane) in the stomach acid environment, and DIM acts as a natural estrogen metabolite modulator.

DIM works by competing for the same metabolizing enzyme (CYP1A2) as estrogen, effectively shunting estrogen metabolism toward the protective 2-hydroxy pathway and away from the potentially harmful 16-alpha-hydroxy and 4-hydroxy pathways. Studies have shown that women who eat cruciferous vegetables 3-5 times per week have measurably better estrogen metabolite ratios, lower rates of estrogen-sensitive cancers, and improved PMS symptoms.

Practical cruciferous protocol: 1-2 cups daily minimum. Lightly steam for 3-4 minutes to preserve the glucosinolate-converting enzyme myrosinase. If eating cooked/steamed, add fresh mustard seed or a touch of wasabi to reactivate the conversion pathway. Rotate between broccoli, cauliflower, kale, Brussels sprouts, cabbage, arugula, and bok choy for microbiome diversity.

The Seed Cycling Protocol — Complete Guide

Seed cycling is a naturopathic practice of eating specific seeds during each phase of the menstrual cycle to provide targeted phytonutrients that support the dominant hormones of each phase. While large clinical trials are limited, the nutritional rationale is sound and many women report significant improvements in PMS, cycle regularity, and hormonal balance. It takes a minimum of 3 cycles to see full effects.

Cycle Phase	Days	Seeds	Amount	Key Nutrients	Mechanism
Follicular	1-14	Flaxseeds + Pumpkin seeds	1 tbsp each ground daily	Lignans, zinc, omega-3, phyt oestrogens	Flax lignans modulate estrogen receptors; pumpkin seeds provide zinc for follicle development and ovulation
Luteal	15-28	Sesame seeds + Sunflower seeds	1 tbsp each ground daily	Lignans, vitamin E, selenium, omega-6	Sesame lignans support estrogen clearance; sunflower seeds provide vitamin E and selenium for progesterone production

Flaxseed Usage Guide

- Always grind fresh — whole flaxseeds pass through undigested; pre-ground goes rancid quickly
- Store in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 1 week
- Start with 1 tbsp and build to 2 tbsp over 2 weeks to avoid digestive discomfort
- Add to smoothies (invisible and tasteless), yogurt, oatmeal, salad dressings, or baked goods
- Golden and brown flaxseeds have similar nutritional profiles; choose based on taste preference
- Do not heat flaxseed — it's best added after cooking or to cold/room temperature foods
- Target: 2 tablespoons freshly ground daily (days 1-14 for cycle syncing)

SECTION 4: PROGESTERONE-SUPPORTING FOODS

The Progesterone Nutrition Protocol

Progesterone cannot be obtained directly from food — it's synthesized from pregnenolone, which is made from cholesterol. What food CAN do is provide all the cofactors needed for this synthesis, reduce the cortisol steal that depletes progesterone, and support the ovulation without which no progesterone is produced in the second half of the cycle.

Nutrient	Role in Progesterone	Best Food Sources	Optimal Intake
Zinc	Required for LH surge triggering ovulation; without ovulation, no progesterone	Oysters, pumpkin seeds, beef, chickpeas, cashews, hemp seeds	30mg/day
Vitamin B6 (P5P)	Cofactor in progesterone synthesis pathway; reduces estrogen dominance	Chicken, tuna, salmon, sunflower seeds, pistachios, bananas	50-100mg as P5P
Vitamin C	Corpus luteum (progesterone-producing structure) is highest in vitamin C	Bell peppers, kiwi, citrus, strawberries, guava, broccoli	1000-2000mg from food + supplement
Magnesium	Reduces cortisol (which steals pregnenolone from progesterone pathway)	Pumpkin seeds, dark chocolate, almonds, spinach, black beans	400mg/day
Cholesterol	Direct precursor to all steroid hormones including progesterone	Egg yolks, fatty fish, grass-fed butter, meat, full-fat dairy	Do not restrict dietary fat
Selenium	Supports thyroid which regulates progesterone synthesis signalling	Brazil nuts (2/day), sardines, tuna, eggs, sunflower seeds	200mcg/day

Nutrient	Role in Progesterone	Best Food Sources	Optimal Intake
L-Arginine	Supports corpus luteum blood flow for progesterone production	Pumpkin seeds, turkey, chicken, lentils, peanuts, spirulina	From food; 2-6g if supplementing

SECTION 5: THYROID & ADRENAL NUTRITION

Thyroid-Supporting Nutrition

Your thyroid gland requires a specific set of nutrients to produce hormones (selenium, iodine, tyrosine) and to convert inactive T4 into active T3 (selenium, zinc, iron). Deficiency in any of these creates functional hypothyroidism even when the gland itself is structurally normal. Additionally, certain foods called goitrogens can interfere with thyroid hormone synthesis — though this is largely dose-dependent and only relevant when thyroid is already compromised.

- Selenium 200mcg daily: critical for T4→T3 conversion and anti-Hashimoto's antibody reduction
- Iodine from food: nori seaweed (1 sheet provides ~50mcg), seafood, eggs — avoid excess supplemental iodine without testing
- Zinc 25-30mg: supports T4 synthesis and T3 receptor sensitivity
- Iron (ferritin): must be above 70 for normal thyroid function — test, don't guess
- Goitrogens in large raw amounts (cruciferous veg, soy, millet) — lightly cooking deactivates them
- Gluten elimination trial: 90% of Hashimoto's patients have gluten antibodies; molecular mimicry is real
- Avoid fluoride in water, fluoride toothpaste, and chlorine in tap water — all displace iodine from thyroid

Adrenal Nutrition Protocol

Your adrenal glands are the most nutritionally demanding glands in the body. They contain the highest concentration of vitamin C of any organ (using it up rapidly during stress), require B vitamins (especially B5) for cortisol synthesis, and need adequate sodium, potassium, and magnesium for proper fluid balance and nerve signalling. When under chronic stress, these glands have increased nutritional demands that standard diets often can't meet.

The Adrenal Cocktail Recipe

Morning adrenal support drink (take 30 min before breakfast): Juice of $\frac{1}{2}$ orange (natural vitamin C + potassium), $\frac{1}{4}$ tsp sea salt or pink Himalayan salt (sodium for adrenal function), $\frac{1}{4}$ tsp cream of tartar (high potassium), $\frac{1}{2}$ cup water. Optionally add: $\frac{1}{4}$ tsp magnesium powder, a pinch of zinc, a squeeze of lemon. This combination directly nourishes adrenal function and helps regulate cortisol output.

SECTION 6: CYCLE-SYNCD EATING GUIDE

Eat with Your Hormones, Not Against Them

Cycle syncing your nutrition means adjusting what you eat based on where you are in your menstrual cycle to support the dominant hormones of each phase. This approach reduces PMS, improves energy throughout the month, supports mood stability, optimizes fertility, and makes weight management easier by working with your body's natural rhythms.

Phase	Days	Hormones	Nutritional Focus	Key Foods	Foods to Minimize
Menstrual	1-5	E+P lowest	Iron replenishment, anti-inflammatory, warming foods, gentle digestion	Organ meat or red meat, lentils, dark leafy greens, beets, ginger tea, bone broth, warming spices	Cold foods, raw vegetables (hard to digest), alcohol, caffeine
Follicular	6-13	Estrogen rising	Light, varied, fermented foods, estrogen modulation, liver support	Eggs, fermented foods, cruciferous veg, fresh salads, citrus, seeds, sprouted grains	Heavy, hard-to-digest foods

Phase	Days	Hormones	Nutritional Focus	Key Foods	Foods to Minimize
Ovulatory	14-17	E+T peak	Anti-inflammatory, light and nourishing, antioxidant-rich	Raw vegetables and salads, avocado, coconut, light proteins, fresh fruit, quinoa	Processed foods, alcohol
Luteal	18-28	P rises then drops	Blood sugar stability, magnesium-rich, B vitamin focus, complex carbs increase	Root vegetables, squash, dark chocolate, figs, pumpkin seeds, turkey, complex carbs, warming soups	Caffeine (worsens PMS), alcohol, refined sugar, salty processed foods

SECTION 7: THE 28-DAY HORMONE MEAL PLAN

Week 1: Menstrual Phase — Restoration

During your period, estrogen and progesterone are at their lowest, metabolism is slightly elevated (you actually burn a few extra calories), and your body is focused on shedding and renewal. Prioritize iron, B12, warming foods, and anti-inflammatory nutrition. Avoid raw, cold, and hard-to-digest foods.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Snack
Day 1	Warming oatmeal: ground flaxseed, cinnamon, berries, walnuts, ginger	Bone broth soup with lentils, kale, root vegetables, turmeric	Lamb stew with root vegetables, rosemary, served with quinoa	Ginger tea + dark chocolate
Day 2	Soft-boiled eggs with sautéed spinach, avocado, sourdough toast	Warm lentil salad with roasted beets, goat cheese, balsamic	Grass-fed beef mince with bok choy, garlic, brown rice	Herbal tea + handful walnuts
Day 3	Chia pudding (warmed) with stewed berries, flaxseed, cinnamon	Turkey and vegetable soup with bone broth, ginger, turmeric	Baked salmon with roasted sweet potato, steamed broccoli	Apple slices + almond butter
Day 4	Overnight oats with flaxseed, banana, almond butter, cinnamon	Chickpea and vegetable curry (warming spices), brown rice	Slow-cooked chicken thighs, root vegetables, rosemary	Pumpkin seeds + herbal tea
Day 5	Smoothie: banana, spinach, flaxseed, ginger, coconut milk, protein	Warming grain bowl: farro, roasted veg, soft egg, tahini	Beef and vegetable stir-fry, ginger-tamari sauce, cauli rice	Dates stuffed with almond butter

Week 2: Follicular Phase — Build & Energize

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Snack
Day 6	Green smoothie: spinach, cucumber, lemon, hemp seeds, avocado, ginger	Arugula salad: sardines, capers, olive oil, lemon, radishes	Zucchini noodles with pesto, cherry tomatoes, grilled chicken	Fresh fruit salad
Day 7	Poached eggs on avocado toast, microgreens, hemp seeds	Cruciferous slaw: shredded broccoli, cabbage, apple, lemon-tahini	Light fish tacos in lettuce wraps, mango salsa, guacamole	Cucumber slices + hummus
Day 8	Yogurt parfait: coconut yogurt, berries, granola, flaxseed, honey	Buddha bowl: quinoa, kale, roasted chickpeas, tahini dressing	Grilled salmon, asparagus, mixed green salad, lemon vinaigrette	Trail mix with seeds and nuts
Day 9	Acai bowl: acai, banana, topped with granola, seeds, berries	Spring rolls with tofu/shrimp, vermicelli, fresh herbs, dipping sauce	Thai basil chicken with broccoli, bell peppers, cauli rice	Kiwi + herbal tea
Day 10	Scrambled eggs with smoked salmon, capers, fresh dill	Kale Caesar with grilled chicken, pumpkin seeds, avocado	White fish with roasted cherry tomatoes, olives, herbs, quinoa	Celery + almond butter

SECTION 8: HORMONE-BALANCING RECIPES

Breakfasts

Seed Cycling Power Smoothie

Prep time: 5 min

Ingredients:

- 1 tbsp ground flaxseed (follicular) or sesame seeds (luteal)
- 1 tbsp pumpkin seeds (follicular) or sunflower seeds (luteal)
- 1 cup frozen wild blueberries
- 1 large handful baby spinach
- ½ avocado
- 1 scoop vanilla protein powder (25g)
- 1 cup unsweetened coconut milk
- ½ cup filtered water
- 1 tsp maca powder
- ½ inch fresh ginger, peeled

Instructions:

1. Add all ingredients to blender
2. Blend on high 60 seconds until completely smooth
3. Add more liquid if needed to reach desired consistency
4. Pour into glass and consume immediately — seeds oxidize quickly
5. Note: use flax + pumpkin days 1-14; switch to sesame + sunflower days 15-28

Hormone Benefits

Lignans for estrogen balance, omega-3s for inflammation, maca for adrenal support

Hormone-Balance Overnight Oats

Prep time: 5 min + overnight

Ingredients:

- ½ cup organic rolled oats
- 1 tbsp ground flaxseed
- 1 tbsp chia seeds
- 1 cup unsweetened almond milk
- ½ cup frozen blueberries
- 1 scoop collagen peptides
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- ½ tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tbsp almond butter
- Pinch sea salt

Instructions:

1. Combine oats, flaxseed, chia, collagen, cinnamon, vanilla, and salt in jar
2. Pour almond milk over mixture and stir well
3. Add almond butter on top
4. Cover and refrigerate overnight (minimum 4 hours)
5. In morning, top with blueberries and additional toppings if desired

Hormone Benefits

Blood sugar stability, lignans for estrogen, collagen for gut lining and hormone precursors

DIM-Rich Green Power Eggs

Prep time: 10 min

Ingredients:

- 3 organic eggs
- 1 cup broccoli florets, finely chopped
- ½ cup kale, stems removed, chopped
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- ¼ avocado, sliced
- 1 tbsp ghee or olive oil
- Pinch turmeric
- Sea salt and pepper to taste
- Fresh herbs to serve (parsley or chives)

Instructions:

1. Steam broccoli 3-4 minutes (preserves myrosinase enzyme for DIM activation)
2. Heat ghee in skillet over medium heat, add garlic, cook 30 seconds
3. Add kale and cook 2 minutes until wilted
4. Whisk eggs with turmeric, salt, pepper
5. Push vegetables to side, add eggs, scramble gently together
6. Serve with sliced avocado and fresh herbs

Hormone Benefits

DIM precursors from cruciferous veg for estrogen metabolism, protein and fat for satiety and hormone synthesis

Lunches

Cruciferous Hormone Bowl

Ingredients:

- 2 cups mixed cruciferous: shredded raw kale, steamed broccoli, roasted Brussels sprouts
- ½ cup cooked quinoa
- ¼ cup chickpeas (roasted)
- ¼ avocado
- 2 tbsp pumpkin seeds
- Dressing: 2 tbsp tahini, 1 tbsp lemon juice, 1 tsp apple cider vinegar, 1 clove garlic, water to thin

Instructions:

1. Steam broccoli 4 min; massage kale with pinch salt for 2 min until softened
2. Roast Brussels sprouts 400°F/200°C with olive oil 20 min until crispy
3. Combine all vegetables with quinoa and chickpeas
4. Blend dressing ingredients
5. Pour dressing, top with pumpkin seeds

Hormone Benefits

Three cruciferous vegetables for maximum DIM production; zinc from pumpkin seeds for progesterone

Estrogen-Clearing Detox Salad

Ingredients:

- 3 cups arugula (natural DIM precursor)
- ½ cup shredded raw beet (betaine for liver methylation)
- ¼ cup pomegranate seeds (aromatase inhibitor)
- 2 tbsp toasted walnuts

- 1 can wild sardines (selenium + omega-3)
- Dressing: 3 tbsp olive oil, 2 tbsp lemon juice, 1 tsp Dijon, pinch cumin, sea salt

Instructions:

1. Combine arugula, beet, pomegranate, walnuts in bowl
2. Place drained sardines on top
3. Whisk dressing and drizzle over salad
4. Top with fresh herbs if desired

Hormone Benefits

Arugula DIM precursors, beet liver methylation support, pomegranate aromatase inhibition, sardines selenium and omega-3

SECTION 9: THE COMPLETE SUPPLEMENT GUIDE

Building Your Hormone Supplement Stack

The optimal approach to supplementation is to start with a targeted foundation (addressing universal deficiencies), then add specific support based on your hormone type and lab results. More supplements are not necessarily better — bioavailability, form, dose, and timing matter enormously. A few high-quality supplements taken consistently and correctly will outperform a cabinet full of low-grade products taken haphazardly.

Supplement	Optimal Form	Dose	Timing	Cycle Timing	Duration
Magnesium	Glycinate or malate	300-400mg	Evening	Daily throughout cycle	Ongoing — most women need this indefinitely
Vitamin D3	D3 (cholecalciferol) + K2 (MK-7)	3000-5000 IU D3 + 100mcg K2	With fat meal	Daily	Test every 6 months; target 50-80 ng/mL
Omega-3	Triglyceride form, >50% EPA+DHA	2-3g combined EPA+DHA	With main meal	Daily	Ongoing; especially critical days 14-28
DIM	BioResponse DIM or plain DIM with oil	100-200mg	With largest meal	Days 1-14 (follicular)	3-6 months; then maintenance
Vitex	Standardized extract (0.5% agnusides)	400-600mg	Morning empty stomach	Daily throughout cycle	3-6 months minimum; slow to work
Zinc	Zinc picolinate or bisglycinate	25-30mg	With dinner	Daily	3 months; test if supplementing >3 months

Supplement	Optimal Form	Dose	Timing	Cycle Timing	Duration
B6	P5P (pyridoxal-5-phosphate)	50mg	With food	Days 14-28 especially	3 months cycles
Selenium	Selenomethionine or from 2 Brazil nuts	200mcg	Morning	Daily	Ongoing; don't exceed 400mcg
Ashwagandha	KSM-66 or Sensoril (both validated)	300-600mg	Evening	Daily	3 months on, 1 month off
Berberine (PCOS/insulin)	Berberine HCl	500mg	With meals 2-3x daily	Daily	3-6 months; take breaks
Inositol (PCOS)	Myo-inositol: D-chiro-inositol (40:1)	4g myo + 100mg D-chiro	Morning + evening	Daily	6+ months for full PCOS benefit
Iron (only if deficient)	Ferrous bisglycinate (gentlest form)	25mg elemental iron	Away from food	Daily or every other day	Until ferritin reaches 70+; then reduce

SECTION 10: MEAL PREP & BATCH COOKING

The Weekly Hormone Meal Prep System

Consistent hormone-supportive eating requires preparation. The biggest barrier most women face is not knowing what to eat in the moment — when you're hungry and the easiest option is the most processed. A 1.5-hour Sunday prep session completely solves this problem by having ready-to-assemble components available all week.

- Batch cook 2 cups dry grains: quinoa, brown rice, or farro for the week
- Roast a large tray of mixed cruciferous vegetables: broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cauliflower with olive oil
- Hard boil 6-8 eggs (lasts 5 days in fridge) for fast protein throughout the week
- Prepare 2 large salad bases in mason jars (dressing separate)
- Make a big batch of bone broth or use store-bought organic — keeps 5 days refrigerated
- Pre-portion snacks: 1 oz mixed nuts, seed trail mix, apple + nut butter portions
- Grind 1-2 weeks of flaxseeds and store in airtight container in fridge
- Marinate proteins Sunday evening for Monday and Tuesday cooking
- Batch cook a large pot of legumes: lentils or chickpeas for salads, soups, and bowls
- Make one signature sauce or dressing: tahini-lemon, miso-ginger, avocado-lime

Hormone-Safe Food Storage

Use glass or stainless containers — not plastic. Plastic containers (even BPA-free) leach chemicals into food especially when warm or acidic. BPA-free plastics often contain BPS, which has similar hormone-disrupting effects. Invest in a set of glass meal prep containers: they last forever, look better, and protect your hormones.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Q: Do I need to eat organic?

A: Prioritize organic for the EWG Dirty Dozen (strawberries, spinach, kale, apples, grapes, etc.). Conventional is fine for the Clean Fifteen. For animal products, prioritize organic/pasture-raised as hormones and antibiotics concentrate in fat.

Q: I hate fish — how do I get omega-3s?

A: Algae-based omega-3 supplements are identical to fish oil (fish get their omega-3 from algae). Take 2-3g daily. Also focus on ground flaxseed and walnuts for ALA, though conversion to EPA/DHA is limited.

Q: Is intermittent fasting good for hormones?

A: Only in specific situations. Women who are already stressed, under-eating, or in the luteal phase can worsen their hormones with fasting. If considering it, keep the eating window to 12-14 hours maximum, eat in the morning and afternoon, and don't fast on high-exercise days.

Q: How important is breakfast?

A: Very important for cortisol regulation. Eating within 30-60 minutes of waking blunts the cortisol awakening response and stabilizes blood sugar for the day. Skipping breakfast in favor of coffee raises cortisol further and depletes adrenals.